the US did not do so, he would move toward Beijing.[237] The State Department conveyed Johnson's message that such an American promise would not be forthcoming, especially as long as Pakistan seemed tethered to the Chinese position. Rusk also warned Pakistani officials, "President Johnson is not the sort of man who will ever give his approval to one thin dime for a country which supports or encourages the aggressive pressures of Red China."[238]

While preparing to support India in the event of Chinese intervention, the Johnson administration was careful about making any specific commitment to Delhi, lest its support delay India's path to the negotiating table.[239] Washington was also cautious about publicly promising any support against China—intelligence assessments had indicated that if the US appeared to be getting involved on India's behalf, it would make Chinese intervention on Pakistan's side more likely.[240] Thus, in the early stages of the crisis, the State Department had demurred from restating US assurances in the event of a communist attack on India as Bowles urged.[241] When the Indian ambassador brought up the possibility of Chinese intervention, Johnson gave no indication of the potential US response while agreeing that it was "giving us gray hairs right now." He added that any public indication of US support would only be provocative.[242] In Delhi, Radhakrishnan asked Bowles what India could expect from the US if China intervened; the ambassador said it would depend on the circumstances.[243]

The Indian side continued to ask for assurances and pressure on China and Pakistan. Shastri requested that Johnson make clear to Pakistan that if third parties intervened on its behalf, the US would have to reconsider its neutrality.[244] Delhi was not just using the China threat instrumentally. The Indian concern about Chinese intervention was real.[245] It was one of the reasons India did not take action on its eastern border with Pakistan in case that gave China a pretext to attack.[246]

Foreign Minister Swaran Singh told Bowles he expected Beijing to act once its deadline expired. American intelligence had not detected any Chinese preparations for a "major military move" against India, but felt Beijing "could easily engage in a show of force to divert Indian troops."[247] In Washington on September 17, on Singh's instructions, B. K. Nehru asked the US to warn Beijing formally as a deterrent and requested US assistance in the event of a Chinese attack. Asked if India was invoking the Air